

English: Intonation Study Notes

1. Core Concepts

Intonation = the variation of pitch when speaking.

Pitch = frequency: speaking higher or lower.

- Pitch goes **down** at the end of: a sentence, an expression of certainty, a full ending.
- Pitch goes **up** at the end of: a question, an expression of uncertainty.

Melody = the way intonation is perceived — think of it as a series of notes, similar to music. It's often easier to notice pitch changes when listening to music/melody rather than focusing on the words themselves.

Rhythm = the pattern created by alternating stressed/unstressed (high/low) words in speech. This is a more advanced aspect of American English.

Stress = which words (or syllables within a word) get emphasized. Depends on context. Stressed elements are higher in pitch and longer.

These four concepts are closely interconnected: melody is essentially what decides which words get stressed, rhythm is the resulting pattern of stressed/unstressed words, and pitch is the raw tool (frequency) used to create both.

2. Importance of Intonation

What it does:

- Helps organize the message and makes it clearer — it functions like punctuation.
- Helps speech sound more interesting and engaging.
- Same sentence, with different words stressed, can carry a different meaning — stress is part of how the message is understood.
- People understand words based on their stress pattern, which is why word-level stress matters too (see section 5).

What happens when it's missing or done differently:

- **Monotonous** speech = no pitch/intonation variation. Sounds more boring.
- A higher pitch tends to sound nicer / friendlier / more polite; a lower pitch can sound more unfriendly, even rude.
- Being wary of the **upspeak** pattern (pitch constantly rising) — it can make you sound uncertain.
- In some languages, volume is used to stress words instead of pitch. This is different from English, and can unintentionally make speakers sound rude to others.
- Because melody works so differently across languages, the main focus when improving should be on **prosody and intonation** rather than just words/grammar.

3. Rhythm

American rhythm is about the balance between low and high, stressed and unstressed.

Two groups of words:

- **Content words:** nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs.
- **Function words:** smaller connecting words — prepositions, articles, etc.

Rules of thumb:

- Content words are usually **stressed**.
- Function words are usually **unstressed**.
- Stressed words are higher in pitch and longer (longer vowels).
- Speech usually goes down for function words.
- Melody is what decides which words get stressed / raised in pitch.
- Function words are **reduced** — almost “hidden” — by reducing their vowels to a schwa.

Rhythm depends on the message / what you’re trying to say: less important words are reduced so that the important ones stand out.

4. Listening and Recognition

- Recognizing stress patterns — how native speakers actually speak — helps a lot with improvement.
- Notice the difference between people who use varied intonation vs. those who sound monotone.
- Try to imitate the music/melody of speech.
 - Be careful: the brain might trick you into “hearing” something that isn’t quite there.
 - It’s okay to not fully understand or consciously listen — just imitate.
- Find someone whose voice / pitch you like, and use them as a model to imitate.
- Try to detect patterns that people repeat often. If you like them, adopt them.

5. Stress Within a Word

- Use a higher pitch for the **primary stress** of a word.
- Primary stress placement is inconsistent (no fixed rule).
- Words are divided into syllables, and each syllable can carry a different level of stress.
- Every content word must have a primary stress.

Types of stress:

1. Primary stress
2. Secondary stress
3. Weak stress (reduced to schwa) — lower pitch and shorter.

Identifying primary stress:

- One technique: say the word slowly and think about which part would need emphasis. (Feels a bit artificial as a method — also unclear what to do if you don’t already know the word.)
- People understand words based on stress patterns, which is why it matters.

Patterns (with exceptions):

- Two-syllable words: verbs are usually stressed on the second syllable, nouns on the first — but there are many exceptions.

- Some words change stress depending on their function: e.g., *to reCORD* (verb, 2nd syllable) vs. *a REcord* (noun, 1st syllable).
- Good practice: compare with a dictionary to confirm the primary stress of a word.
- Practice by exaggerating the syllable with primary stress: make it much longer and/or much higher in pitch.
- Longer words often have suffixes (e.g., *possible* → *possibility*). For many of these, the stress shifts to the syllable just before the suffix.

6. Possible Exercises

- Take sentences with one highlighted word each time; say the sentence stressing that word. Can also read the same sentence multiple times, stressing a different word each time.
- Listen to podcasts at ~50% speed (or a bit more/less): easier to notice intonation changes. Practice the melody, repeat it over and over. Then return to normal speed. Think of it more like musical notes.
- Listen to a podcast at 50% speed and try to repeat/imitate the melody/rhythm — even if it's not accurate at first.
- Analyze popular TED talks: get the transcript, mark the stressed words. (*Not fully convinced this is a good exercise.*)
- Memorize a monologue (including its melody). Helps create speech patterns. (*To be tried — not fully convinced.*)
- Sing the melody of a sentence: play it at half speed, and hum/repeat the melody instead of the words. (*Good in theory, but feels very hard in practice.*)
- Compare French vs. English intonation: say the same sentence in both languages and compare. (*Not sure if this is really useful.*)

Raw Notes

Intonation = variation of pitch when we speak.

Pitch is frequency: speaking higher / lower.

Pitch go down at the end: sentence, certainty, full end

Pitch go up at the end: question, uncertainty

Consider melody (the notes)

Think about stress (which words to stress in a sentence), depend on context.

Easier to notice pitch when music / melody instead of words.

Intonation helps organize message, makes it clearer (it's like the punctuation).

Also helps sound more interesting and engaging.

Monotonous: no pitch / intonation variance. More boring.

Use higher notes for the most important / stressed note.

Rhythm: American rhythm, more advanced. Balanced vs low / high, stress / unstressed

2 groups of words: content words (nouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs), function words (other small words to connect content words: prepositions, articles, etc).

Stress content words usually, unstress functions words.

Stress words: higher in pitch and longer (longer vowels)

Speech Going down (usually) for function words
Melody is deciding which words to stress / go higher in pitch
Function words are reduced (almost like hiding them): we reduce vowels to schwa.

Rhythm depends on your message / what you trying to say: words less important are reduced to allow the rest to stick out.
Same sentence but stressing different words might mean something different.

Which a higher pitch seems nicer / friendly / polite. Lower pitch can seem more unfriendly, even rude.

Recognizing stress pattern, how native speakers speak help a lot to improve.

Notice people using more varied intonation vs monotone.

In some languages we use volume to stress words, which is different in English.
And we seem rude to others because of that.
Needs to mainly focus on prosody and intonation because melody is so different in some other languages.
Try to imitate the music / melody of speak. Be careful, brain might trick you into hearing something else. Ok to not understand / listen, just imitate.
Find someone you like his voice / pitch etc to imitate.

Be wary about upspeak pattern (going always up and up, makes you feel uncertain)

Try to detect patterns that people use it over and over again. If you like them, use them

Stress within a word:
Higher pitch for primary stress of a word.
Primary stress is inconsistent.
Word divided in syllables, each may having different level of stress. Every content word must have a primary stress.
Types of stress: primary stress, secondary stress, weak stress (aka reduced to schwa).
Weak stress lower pitch and shorter.
How to identify primary stress ? Say it slowly, think which part would need to be emphasized ? (Find this technique a bit fake. What if don't know the word ?)
In general stress is inconsistent.
People understand word based on stress, that's why it's important.
Word with 2 syllables: verb usually second syllable, noun usually first. But many exceptions.
some words actually have different stress depending: eg to record (2nd), a record (1st).
Good way to try and compare with a dictionary to make sure you know the primary stress of a word.
Practice word by saying the word by exaggeration the syllable with primary stress: much longer, and / or vey high pitch
Longer word usually have suffixes: possible _> possibility. For many of them,

stress is one syllable before the suffix.

Possible exercises:

- Sentences with one highlighted word, say it stressing that word. Can also read it multiple times, each time stressing a different word
- Listen to podcasts at 50% (or bit less / more): easier to notice changes of intonation. Practice the melody, repeat it over and over again. Then go back to normal speed. Think more like notes.
- Listen to podcast at 50% and try to repeat / imitate the melody / rhythm . Even if you don't get it at first.
- Analyze Popular Ted talks: get transcript, mark stressed words (actually not so convinced it's a good exercise)
- Memorize a monologue (memorize also the melody). Helps creates patterns of speech. (To try, not convinced either)
- Sing the melody of a sentence: play half speed, repeat the melody of a sentence instead of the words. (Good exercise in theory, but feels very hard)
- Play with French vs english intonation: say sentence in 2 languages, compare (again not sure if this is really useful)